How to Write About Your Art

Part 1: The Artist Statement

ARTIST COMMONS

“Teaching writing is a hustle.”

– Cormac McCarthy

“Beware of advice — even this.”

– Carl Sandberg

Why art?

Nothing just is.

“Never just say, ‘You tell me what it is.’
That’s pompous bullshit…
Important things are hard to write about.
That’s the way it is. Deal with it.”

– Jerry Saltz

How to Be An Artist (2020)

Why do you need an artist statement?

- Curators
- Gallerists/Dealers
- Residencies, Open Calls, Grants
- Juried Awards
- Exhibition Text
- Press Releases
- Personal Website

The goals of an artist statement

- Guide viewers into the work and make them feel welcome.
- Help viewers see the work more clearly.
- Deepen the viewing experience.
- Give viewers a latch point to explore their own thoughts and ideas about the work.
- Help viewers walk away with more than if they'd looked at the work on their own.
- Help viewers invest in your story.

“Just as an artist toils with his or her powers of perception and sense of vision to create a work of art, the viewer toils with his or her own powers of perception and sense of vision to ‘see’ a work of art.”

– Vicki Krohn Amorose

Art-Write: The Writing Guide for Visual Artists

Most art writing is:

- Badly written
- Too long or long in the tooth
- Full of repetition while saying nothing
- Not thought through
- Rushed, or written by underpaid interns
- Worded for an audience of curators and academics

“When it comes to artist statements, keep it simple, stupid. Don’t use art jargon; write in your own voice, write how you talk. Don’t try to write smart. Keep your statement direct, clear, to the point…If it’s pretentious to say, don’t say it.”

– Jerry Saltz

How to Be An Artist (2020)

“People who say they write for themselves write for no one. The reader is the spark that makes your work explode into being.”

– Mary Karr

What should an artist statement do?

- It’s an invitation
- A peak into your mind and process
- Provides context – no artwork should be an island
- Rewards both if read before *or* after viewing the work
- It’s a dialogue with the viewer
- Outlines the contours of the work without being granular

The Three Questions to Ask

1. What is it?
What does it look like? How is it made? What happened?

2. What might this mean?
How does the form or event carry meaning?

3. Why does this matter to the world at large?
What does it contribute to the world? Or, so what?

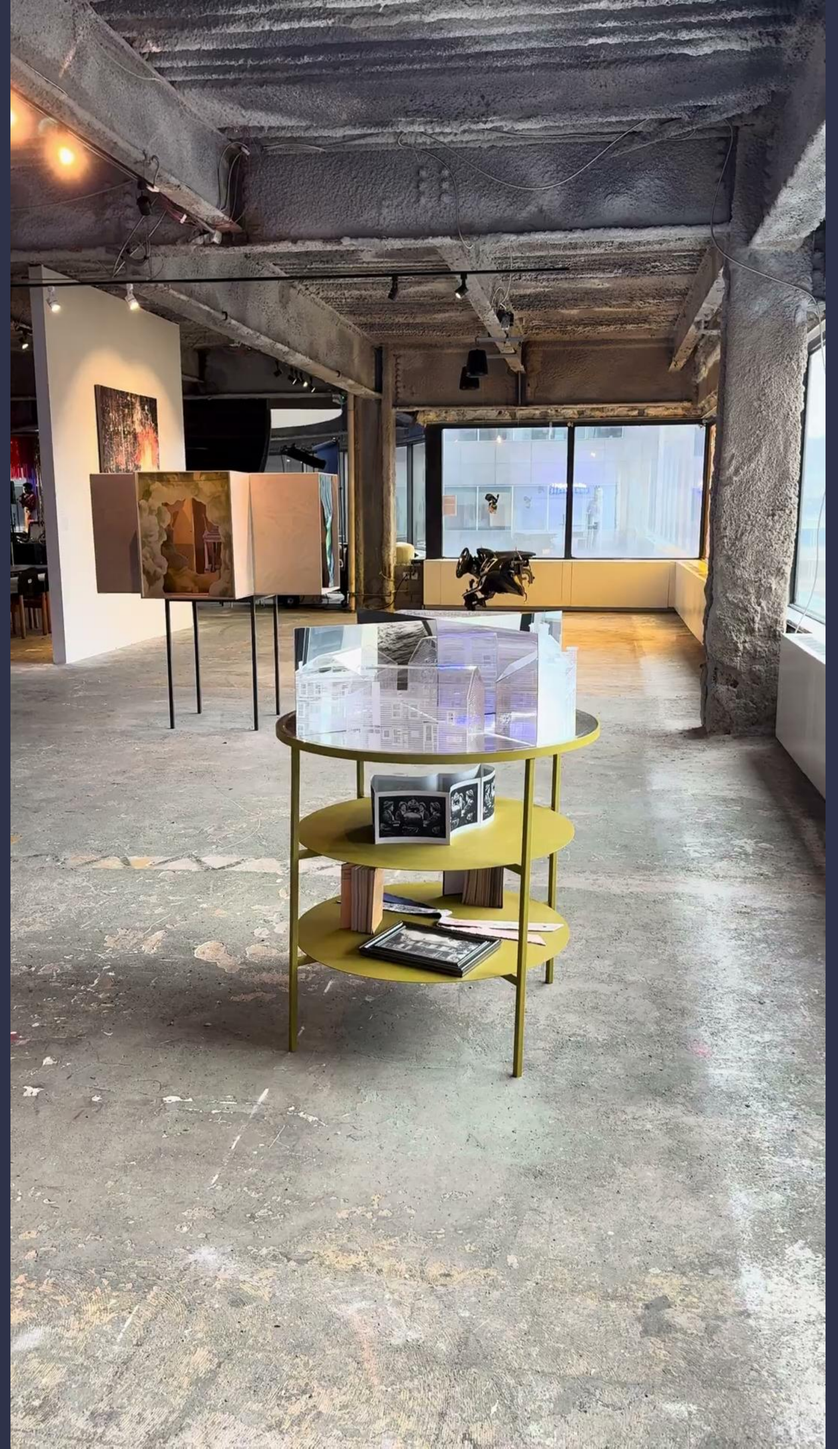
From Gilda Williams's *How to Write About Contemporary Art* (2014)

1. What is it?

- What does it look like?
- How is it made?
- What happened?
- Paint us a picture.

Some advice for explaining the how

- Always place the why before the how.
- The how is just one third of one third of your statement.
- Don’t write for fellow practitioners unless that’s your audience for this particular piece of writing.
- Explain the how like you’re talking to your grandmother.



Britt Ransom
Layered Sites, 2024



Britt Ransom (b. 1987, Lima, OH; based in Pittsburgh, PA and New Orleans, LA)

Layered Sites
Architectural models (acrylic), glass, steel, SLA 3D print, books, multigraph of inkjet, coordinate ribbons, and plastic cast of artist's hand
Courtesy the artist
Special thanks to The Bishop Reverdy C. and Emma S. Ransom Foundation Board of Directors.

Layered Sites are clear, acrylic scale models of three architectural sites that hold embodied abolitionist narratives. The Tawawa Chimney Corner House in Ohio is a national historic landmark for civil rights activism, and the former home of Ransom's great-great grandparents who were prominent leaders for social justice and equality, as well as early founders of the Niagara Movement. John Brown's Fort in Harpers Ferry, West Virginia was the refuge for anti-slavery advocate John Brown during the 1859 raid on Harper's Ferry, in which he initiated an uprising of enslaved people. The Emma Ransom House in Harlem was named after the artist's great-great grandmother, who was a feminist activist and elected chair of the Colored Woman's Branch of the Young Women's Christian Association. It offered affordable living to working-class Black women in the 1920s. Through the layering of these three buildings, Ransom weaves in her family history, allowing it to fill the spaces between preservation and restoration.

Exercise #1

Brainstorm a Word List

1. List all the categories of traits and themes that apply to an artwork of yours: color, movement, time, size, etc.
2. Now copy the strongest categories to a new piece of paper as headings. Leave plenty of space underneath each one.
3. Push yourself to come up with at least 15+ words and phrases under each category heading.

“Quantity produces quality. If you only write a few things, you’re doomed.”

– Ray Bradbury

Exercise #1

Brainstorm a Word List

1. List all the categories of traits and themes that apply to an artwork of yours: color, movement, time, size, etc.
2. Now copy the strongest categories to a new piece of paper as headings. Leave plenty of space underneath each one.
3. Push yourself to come up with at least 15+ words and phrases under each category heading.

Your First Paragraph

- Write in a way that makes someone want to read the next sentence.
- Make what you write personal.
- Be specific and concrete. Draw from the evidence to support what you write.
- Explain the technical aspects as if to your grandmother.
- Use accessible language.

Bad Writing Isn’t Specific or Concrete

“Always seeking to expand notions of what an image can be, Lassry produces pictures that escape their indexical relationships by highlighting their formal properties and by opening the way for questions regarding their connection to specific cultural contexts. The pictures become sites where an image becomes a mere object, and thus places where Lassry questions the fundamental conditions of seeing.

In the current exhibition, wall-based sculptural objects that resemble cabinets call to mind several properties (size ratios, seriality, and modularity) characteristic of Lassry’s pictures. However, the apparent utility of the cabinets as vessels allows them to be read as paradoxes, photographs that have been fleshed out as objects but evacuated as representations.”

“You don’t have to translate into words the entire content of what you’ve already expressed visually! Your task is to give your audience a compelling reason to look closer. Help them look.”

– Vicki Krohn Amorose

Art-Write: The Writing Guide for Visual Artists

Exercise #2

What is it?

1. Write your opening “What is it?” paragraph.
2. Pull from your word and phrase list.
3. Balance between questions like: What does it look like? How is it made? What happened?
4. Sequence the sentences by essentialness.
5. Be specific and concrete.
6. Don’t get lost in the details.

“Art is not what you see, but what you make others see.”

– Edgar Degas

“All paths lead to the same goal: to convey what we are.”

– Pablo Neruda

The Three Questions to Ask

1. What is it?
What does it look like? How is it made? What happened?

2. What might this mean?
How does the form or event carry meaning?

3. Why does this matter to the world at large?
What does it contribute to the world? Or, so what?

From Gilda Williams's *How to Write About Contemporary Art* (2014)